

Government surveillance, explained through evidence.

What the public record supports. What it leaves unanswered. Where a claim goes too far.

Edition 2.0 | Reviewed 3 October 2026

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Focused assessments

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Traceable sources

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Clearly defined verdicts

A capability is not a measure of your personal risk.

This report examines selected surveillance claims involving U.S. agencies and one U.K. collaboration. It does not estimate how often conspiracy theories are true, whether a particular reader is being monitored, or the full extent of classified activity.

How to use this report

Read the exact assertion and its verdict. Then read the evidence, the limitations and the conditions together. Follow the numbered source links to inspect the underlying material.

Reading map

Page 2: review method and verdicts. Pages 3-9: thirteen assessments. Pages 10-11: linked source register. The website includes a searchable index and plain-language glossary.

Confidence needs context.

Define the assertion

A claim about the existence of a tool is different from claims about its creator, deployment, effectiveness, or reach. Each conclusion applies only to the exact assertion in its heading.

Identify the source

Court records and official publications document institutional accounts. Vendor documentation describes product architecture. Leaked documents may describe plans or capabilities; we do not independently authenticate every leaked item. Publisher interpretation and reader comments are not treated as the underlying record.

Keep the boundary visible

Research interest does not establish a working tool. A working tool does not establish use in a particular case. Use in one operation does not establish universal surveillance. Those are separate evidentiary steps.

The verdicts

Supported - the reviewed sources support the specific, limited assertion.

Not established - the reviewed sources are insufficient for the assertion. This is not a finding that every possible version of the claim is false.

Dates, selection and limits

The review date is the date of this edition, not the date a capability was invented or last used. Historical examples are explicitly dated. This report does not claim to describe current surveillance law or every modern implementation.

The collection is editorially selected, not statistically representative. Definitions are excluded from claim counts. No verdict percentage is presented as a measure of the truth of conspiracy theories.

Corrections and maintenance

A useful correction identifies a claim, a source and the exact conclusion the source supports. Record the reason and review date when changing an assessment. The website and PDF are generated from the same data to keep their conclusions aligned.

01. The FBI has used malware to identify people using Tor.

SUPPORTED | [Court record](#)

A court opinion documents an FBI technique that made computers send identifying information.

What the evidence establishes

In the Playpen investigation, the NIT collected information including IP addresses from computers that accessed the site. [\[1\]](#)

What it does not establish

This does not establish a universal Tor bypass or that every investigative tool is a keylogger.

Conditions & context

The finding concerns a specific investigation and deployed code, not all Tor users.

FBI | 2015 operation; 2019 opinion

Sources: [\[1\]](#) U.S. Court of Appeals, Fifth Circuit (via Justia)

02. Antivirus companies are required to ignore government malware.

NOT ESTABLISHED | [Evidence gap](#)

The sources reviewed here do not establish a general requirement to whitelist government malware.

What the evidence establishes

The Ganzer opinion establishes FBI malware use, but it does not establish antivirus-company cooperation. [\[1\]](#)

What it does not establish

Evasion, voluntary cooperation and a legal obligation are separate claims. Evidence for one cannot stand in for the others.

Conditions & context

A defensible assessment needs a named vendor, tool, date and policy or legal document. This verdict is limited to the reviewed evidence.

FBI | Broad claim in the previous edition

Sources: [\[1\]](#) U.S. Court of Appeals, Fifth Circuit (via Justia)

03. Intel ME and AMD PSP are proven NSA backdoors.

NOT ESTABLISHED | [Vendor documentation](#)

The components exist. Their existence does not establish that the NSA ordered a backdoor.

What the evidence establishes

Intel describes an embedded controller with independent power states. AMD describes a security processor used for secure boot and a hardware root of trust. [\[2\]](#) [\[3\]](#)

What it does not establish

Neither cited document establishes an NSA mandate. The two components should not be treated as identical.

Conditions & context

Intel describes operation while power is available; this is not operation without electricity. Features depend on the platform.

NSA | Intel article 2023; AMD documentation reviewed 2026

Sources: [\[2\]](#) Intel, [\[3\]](#) AMD

04. Dual_EC_DRBG was removed after backdoor concerns.

SUPPORTED | [Official publication](#)

NIST withdrew this random-number algorithm from its final revised recommendation in 2015.

What the evidence establishes

NIST announced a draft removing Dual_EC_DRBG in 2014; the final SP 800-90A revision followed in June 2015. [\[4\]](#) [\[5\]](#)

What it does not establish

The removal establishes a standards decision. It does not by itself prove every claim about NSA exploitation or payments to vendors.

Conditions & context

The conclusion concerns this algorithm, not all encryption or every random-number generator.

NSA / NIST | 2013-2015

Sources: [\[4\]](#) NIST, [\[5\]](#) NIST

05. An implanted device can move data without an internet connection.

SUPPORTED | [Leaked document](#)

The COTTONMOUTH-I entry describes a USB implant with a radio link.

What the evidence establishes

The leaked entry describes wireless communication between implanted hardware and other equipment, including a bridge across an air gap. [6]

What it does not establish

This does not mean an ordinary disconnected computer can automatically transmit its files, or that every USB cable is implanted.

Conditions & context

The described design requires modified hardware and a working radio path. The catalog does not establish how widely it was deployed.

NSA | 2008-era catalog; published 2014

Sources: [6] NSA catalog, reproduced by Schneier on Security

06. NSA implant documents describe modifying equipment through interdiction.

SUPPORTED | [Leaked document](#)

The IRONCHEF entry explicitly describes installing hardware and software through interdiction.

What the evidence establishes

The catalog describes a server implant designed to maintain access through firmware and associated hardware. [7]

What it does not establish

A catalog is evidence of a described capability, not a count of intercepted shipments or proof that every delivered device is altered.

Conditions & context

The entry names a particular server platform and requires an opportunity to install implants. It cannot be generalized to all hardware.

NSA | 2008-era catalog; published 2014

Sources: [7] NSA catalog, reproduced by Schneier on Security

07. The cited surveillance documents prove ordinary microwaves are used to spy.

NOT ESTABLISHED | Evidence gap

The reviewed implant documents do not establish this claim about microwave ovens.

What the evidence establishes

The cited catalog entries concern computer equipment. A separate leaked guide describes an implant for particular smart TVs. [6] [12]

What it does not establish

An unsupported claim is not proof that every possible appliance attack is impossible. A TV implant does not establish a microwave-oven program.

Conditions & context

A specific appliance claim needs a model, mechanism and attributable evidence of the alleged capability or operation.

NSA | Claim assessed against this source set

Sources: [6] NSA catalog, reproduced by Schneier on Security, [12] MI5-attributed guide published in Vault 7

08. NSA-linked attacks targeted Tor users through browser vulnerabilities.

SUPPORTED | Leaked document + first-party response

The cited record concerns attacks on users and their software, not proof of a universal break of Tor.

What the evidence establishes

The Tor Project described browser exploitation in its 2013 response. The archived FOXACID document describes exploitation infrastructure. [8] [9]

What it does not establish

These historical sources do not establish that current Tor versions are vulnerable to the same attacks, or that anonymity is guaranteed.

Conditions & context

Successful exploitation depends on the target software and an opportunity to deliver the attack.

NSA | 2011 document; 2013 response

Sources: [8] The Tor Project / Roger Dingledine, [9] NSA document, hosted by National Security Archive

09. Governments may retain knowledge of vulnerabilities instead of immediately disclosing them.

SUPPORTED | Official publication

A White House explanation acknowledges weighing disclosure against temporary retention.

What the evidence establishes

The 2014 account describes a decision process that considers both security risks and intelligence value. [10]

What it does not establish

It does not establish that vendors routinely supply the NSA with every flaw before a patch. PRISM is a different subject.

Conditions & context

This is a historical policy statement; it does not reveal individual retention decisions or establish present policy.

U.S. government | 2014 policy explanation

Sources: [10] White House / Michael Daniel

10. Vault 7 proves the CIA could carry out untraceable car assassinations.

NOT ESTABLISHED | Leaked planning document

The underlying notes list vehicle systems as a potential mission area, not a demonstrated assassination capability.

What the evidence establishes

The meeting notes include vehicle systems among possible firmware targets. [11]

What it does not establish

The notes do not demonstrate a working vehicle-control tool, a deployment, an assassination or untraceability.

Conditions & context

Research interest, development, successful testing and operational use require different evidence. Only the planning reference is established here.

CIA | October 2014 notes; released 2017

Sources: [11] CIA-attributed document published by WikiLeaks

11. A compromised smart TV could record while appearing switched off.

SUPPORTED | **Leaked document**

A leaked guide describes recording on specific Samsung F-series TVs, including a fake-off mode.

What the evidence establishes

The EXTENDING guide describes microphone recording and USB or nearby Wi-Fi retrieval. WikiLeaks links the tool to Weeping Angel. [12] [13]

What it does not establish

This does not establish that all televisions are affected or that a particular household was monitored.

Conditions & context

The documented version requires close-access USB installation on a compatible TV. Fake-off still requires electrical power.

CIA / MI5 | 2014 guide; released 2017

Sources: [12] MI5-attributed guide published in Vault 7, [13] WikiLeaks

12. The NSA has collected communications through internet-backbone providers.

SUPPORTED | **Official oversight report**

PCLOB describes upstream collection with assistance from backbone providers.

What the evidence establishes

The report distinguishes collection in transit from communications supplied by a service provider. [14]

What it does not establish

This source does not establish universal capture of every message or the current legal rules.

Conditions & context

This entry describes a historical collection method. A broad collection system and an implant targeting one device are different forms of surveillance.

NSA | 2014 oversight account

Sources: [14] Privacy and Civil Liberties Oversight Board

13. PRISM was a program for obtaining communications from service providers.

SUPPORTED | [Official oversight report](#)

PCLOB describes providers supplying communications associated with tasked selectors such as email addresses.

What the evidence establishes

This is a communications-collection process, distinct from acquiring software vulnerabilities. [\[14\]](#)

What it does not establish

The account does not establish unrestricted access to every company database or every user account.

Conditions & context

This is a historical description, not a statement of current surveillance law.

NSA / FBI / CIA | 2014 oversight account

Sources: [\[14\]](#) Privacy and Civil Liberties Oversight Board

What changed from the earlier edition

Bundled claims were split. The antivirus-cooperation assertion and vehicle-assassination inference are no longer presented as established facts. The hardware entry distinguishes Intel and AMD documentation. The random-number-standard timeline separates the 2014 proposal from the final 2015 revision.

The TV entry now states the requirements in the underlying guide. Unsourced payment details and broad legal generalizations were omitted. Definitions are separate from claims; the earlier chart and flashcards were removed.

Inspect the record.

Titles below are clickable. Locators identify the relevant part of each source. All sources were reviewed for this edition on 3 October 2026.

[1] [United States v. Ganzer](#)

U.S. Court of Appeals, Fifth Circuit (via Justia) | 2019-04-24 | Court record
Opinion, factual background: the Playpen NIT and information collected.

[2] [What is Intel Management Engine?](#)

Intel | 2023-09-26 | Vendor documentation
Article 000008927; independent power states and embedded microcontroller.

[3] [AMD PRO Technologies](#)

AMD | Undated; reviewed 2026-10-03 | Vendor documentation
Footnote GD-72: AMD Secure Processor and hardware root of trust.

[4] [NIST removes cryptography algorithm from random number generator recommendations](#)

NIST | 2014-04-21 | Official publication
Announcement of the draft revision removing Dual_EC_DRBG.

[5] [NIST revises key computer security publication on random number generation](#)

NIST | 2015-06-25 | Official publication
Final SP 800-90A Revision 1 removes Dual_EC_DRBG.

[6] [COTTONMOUTH-I catalog entry](#)

NSA catalog, reproduced by Schneier on Security | 2008-era entry; published 2014-03-05 | Leaked document
Reproduced catalog text and linked page image, excluding reader comments.

[7] [IRONCHEF catalog entry](#)

NSA catalog, reproduced by Schneier on Security | 2008-era entry; published 2014-01-03 | Leaked document
Reproduced catalog text: installation through interdiction; excludes reader comments.

Inspect the record.

Titles below are clickable. Locators identify the relevant part of each source. All sources were reviewed for this edition on 3 October 2026.

[8] [Yes, we know about the Guardian article](#)

The Tor Project / Roger Dingledine | 2013-10-04 | First-party technical response
Opening statement about browser exploitation; excludes the archived comments.

[9] [FOXACID standard operating procedure](#)

NSA document, hosted by National Security Archive | 2011-01-01 | Leaked document
Archived document and linked OCR describe exploitation infrastructure.

[10] [Heartbleed: understanding when we disclose cyber vulnerabilities](#)

White House / Michael Daniel | 2014-04-28 | Official publication
Historical explanation of the disclosure-versus-retention decision process.

[11] [Branch Direction Meeting notes](#)

CIA-attributed document published by WikiLeaks | 2014-10-23; released 2017 | Leaked document
Reference section: Potential Mission Areas for EDB, then Firmware Targets.

[12] [EXTENDING User Guide](#)

MI5-attributed guide published in Vault 7 | 2014-04-29; released 2017-04-21 | Leaked document
Printed pp. 2-4: supported TVs, close access, recording and retrieval; pp. 26-27: limits.

[13] [Vault 7: Weeping Angel release](#)

WikiLeaks | 2017-04-21 | Publisher context
Weeping Angel release identifies its relationship to EXTENDING and the CIA/MI5.

[14] [Report on the surveillance program operated pursuant to Section 702 of FISA](#)

Privacy and Civil Liberties Oversight Board | 2014-07-02 | Official oversight report
Printed pp. 7 and 33-35 (PDF pp. 12 and 38-40): PRISM and upstream. Historical account, not current law.